

Miss Rottenmeier Has an Uncomfortable Day

When Heidi woke up the next morning, she had no idea where she was for a moment. She lay in a big, white bed in a large room. Looking around, she saw long, white curtains on the windows, some chairs, and a sofa. There was also a washstand with a lot of interesting items on it. Then, Heidi remembered what had happened the day before.

She got out of bed quickly and got dressed. She wanted to look outside at the sky and the ground like she did at home. But when she tried to look out the windows, they were too high! All she could see were the walls and windows of the buildings across from her. She tried to open the windows to get a better view, but she couldn't. Heidi felt sad, like a little bird trapped in a shiny cage. She sat down on a small stool and thought about home. She missed the melting snow and the first spring flowers she had loved.

Suddenly, the door opened. Tinette, the maid, said sharply, "Breakfast's ready."

Heidi didn't think she was being called because Tinette

looked so unfriendly. She sat quietly, wondering what would happen next. Then Miss Rottenmeier rushed in and said, "What's the matter, Adelheid? Didn't you understand? Come to breakfast!"

Heidi quickly followed her to the dining room, where Clara, smiling, greeted her. Clara looked happier than usual because she was excited about the day.

After breakfast, the girls went to the library. When they were finally left alone there, Heidi asked, "How can I get a view of the town around us?"

Clara, finding the question amusing, suggested, "Open a window and peep out."

"But it's impossible to open them!"

Clara explained that neither of them could open the windows. But she said if Heidi asked Sebastian, he would do it for her. Hearing this, Heidi felt a bit better.

Clara was curious about Heidi's home. Heidi excitedly shared stories of her life in her little mountain hut.

Meanwhile, their tutor had arrived. Miss Rottenmeier was still worrying about having arranged for Heidi to come there. Now she tried to convince the tutor to help her send Heidi away.

But the tutor was a fair man. He liked teaching children, even beginners. Miss Rottenmeier was upset he didn't agree with her. She stormed off and left him to start the lesson. She was only gone a minute when she heard a loud crash and a shout for help. Miss Rottenmeier rushed in to see what had happened. She found books and papers scattered all over the





Tinette calls Heidi to breakfast

floor. There was a tablecloth draped over them. A black river of ink streamed across the room. Heidi was nowhere to be seen.

Miss Rottenmeier was upset. “Everything is soaked with ink! This child only brings trouble!”

Clara watched all of this and found it quite amusing. She explained, “Heidi didn’t mean to do it. She was in a hurry and accidentally pulled down the tablecloth. She probably ran to the window because she heard a carriage. It must have scared her.”

“See, this is what I was telling you, Mr. Candidate. Heidi just doesn’t know how to behave. She doesn’t even know how to sit quietly for her lessons. And where did she go? What would Mr. Sesemann say if she runs away?”

Going downstairs, Miss Rottenmeier found Heidi at the door, staring down the street. She was still curious about the unfamiliar sights and sounds of the town. “What are you doing here?” Miss Rottenmeier demanded. “You can’t just run off like that!”

“I thought I heard the fir trees rustling,” Heidi replied, feeling confused. “But now I can’t see them or hear them at all.” She was thinking of the sounds she loved back home in the mountains.

“Fir trees? Nonsense! We’re not in a forest,” the strict Miss Rottenmeier said. “Now, come and see the mess you’ve made.”

Heidi was surprised when she saw the chaos she had accidentally caused. She hadn’t noticed in her rush.

“This can’t happen again,” Miss Rottenmeier told her sternly. “You need to stay seated during your lessons, or I’ll have to tie you to your chair. Do you understand?”

Heidi nodded and promised to sit still during lessons from then on.

The morning was so busy that there was no time left for more studying after the servants cleaned up the mess. In the afternoon, Heidi had some time alone while Clara was resting. She went to the hall and waited for Sebastian to pass by. “Can I ask you something?” Heidi said when she saw him, noticing that he looked a bit upset. She quickly added that she didn’t mean any trouble.

“Alright, what is it, Miss?” Sebastian asked, a little softer than he had spoken to her before.

“My name isn’t Miss, it’s Heidi. Why don’t you call me that?”

“Miss Rottenmeier told me to call you Miss,” he explained.

“Oh, okay then,” Heidi sighed, feeling a bit sad about having so many names nobody used.

“What do you need help with?” Sebastian asked, ready to assist her.

“Could you open a window for me?” Heidi requested.

“Of course,” he said. He fetched a stool so Heidi could see out the window.

Standing on the stool, Heidi looked out and said disappointingly, “All I see is a street full of stone. Is it the same on the other side of the house?”



“Yes,” answered Sebastian.

“Where can you go to see everything from high up?”

“You can go up the church tower over there.” He pointed towards a tower with a golden dome. “From up there, you can see everything.”

Heidi immediately stepped down from the stool and ran downstairs. Opening the door, she found herself in the street. But she could not see the tower any more. She wandered from street to street. She didn’t dare to speak to any of the busy people. She came to a corner where she saw a young organ grinder with a little monkey on his arm. Heidi ran to him and asked, “Where is the tower with the golden dome?”

“I don’t know,” the boy said.

“Who can tell me?”

“I don’t know.”

“Can you show me another church with a tower?”

“Of course I can.”

“Then come and show me.”

“What are you going to give me for it?” asked the boy, holding out his hand. Heidi had nothing in her pocket but a little picture of a flower. Clara had given it to her this morning, and she didn’t really want to part with it. But she had a strong desire to learn everything she could about her new surroundings. So she offered him the gift. The boy shook his head, which was a relief to Heidi.

“What else do you want?”

“Money.”

“I have none, but Clara has some. How much do I have





Heidi explores the streets of Frankfurt

to give you?”

“Twenty pennies.”

“All right, but let’s go now.”

While they were wandering down the street, Heidi found out what an organ grinder was. She had never seen one. The boy explained that he turned the handle of his organ which made the music come out. People passing by threw coins in his hat if they enjoyed what they heard.

When Heidi and the boy arrived before an old church with a tower, Heidi was puzzled about what to do next. She pulled hard on a rope that rang a bell hanging outside the door. The boy said he would wait for Heidi. He would show her the way home if she gave him forty pennies instead of twenty.

The lock creaked, and an old man opened the door. In an angry voice, he said, “How dare you ring for me? That bell is only for those who want to see the tower.”

“But I do want to see it,” said Heidi.

“What do you want to see? Did anybody send you?” asked the man.

“No. But I want to look down from up there.” Heidi started to cry.

The man softened at the sight of her tears. “All right, come along, if it’s so important to you,” he said, taking her by the hand. The two started climbing up to the top of the tower. The way had many, many steps and got narrower and narrower. When they had arrived on top, the old man lifted Heidi up to the open window.

Heidi saw nothing but a sea of chimneys, roofs, and towers. Her heart sank. "Oh, dear, it's different from the way I thought it would be," she said.

"Don't be so sad! How could such a little girl appreciate a view anyway? We'll go down now, and you need to promise never to ring at my tower ever again."

On their way they passed an attic. There in the shadows, a large grey cat guarded her new family in a basket. This cat caught several mice every day for herself. The old tower was full of rats and mice. Heidi gazed at her in surprise. She was delighted when the old man opened the basket.

"Look at the cute little kittens!" she exclaimed with delight. The kittens crawled all over each other, jumping and tumbling.

"Would you like to have one?" the old man asked.

"For me? To keep?" Heidi asked. She couldn't believe her ears.

"Yes, of course. You can have several if you have room for them," the old man said. He was glad to find a good home for the kittens.

Heidi was so happy! Of course there was enough room in the huge house. And Clara would be delighted when she saw the precious little creatures.

"But how will I carry them?" Heidi asked. She had already tried and failed to catch one of the kittens.

"I can bring them to your house, if you tell me where you live," said Heidi's new friend. He stroked the old cat, who had lived with him many years.



"Bring them to Mr. Sesemann's house. There is a golden dog on the door, with a ring in his mouth."

"I know the house," the old man said. He had lived in the tower a long time and knew everybody. He even knew Sebastian, who was a special friend of his. "But who should I send them to? To Mr. Sesemann?"

"No. Please send them to Clara. She'll love them."

Heidi could hardly tear herself away from the pretty things. The old man put one kitten in each of her pockets to make her feel better. After that she went away.

"Thank you for helping me find this place," Heidi said to the boy. "Now, can you please show me how to get back?"

"Ok, let's go," said the boy, leading the way.

When the boy and Heidi arrived, Sebastian opened the door. "Hurry up," he said and Heidi went in. The boy was left outside. Sebastian hadn't even seen him.

He quickly ushered Heidi inside. "Come up quickly, little Miss," he urged. "They are all waiting for you in the dining room. Miss Rottenmeier is as angry as a loaded cannon. How could you run away like that?"

As Heidi sat down, the dining room was silent and tense. Finally, Miss Rottenmeier began to scold Heidi for going out without permission. But every time Heidi tried to answer, a loud "Meow!" interrupted her.

"That is enough," Miss Rottenmeier tried to say. She was so angry she could barely speak. "Get up and leave the room."

Heidi got up. She began again. "I made—"





Heidi gets kittens to take home



“Meow! Meow! Meow!”

“Heidi,” said Clara now, “why do you keep saying ‘meow’ when you see that Miss Rottenmeier is angry?”

“I’m not doing it, it’s the kittens,” Heidi explained.

“What? Cats? Kittens?” screamed the housekeeper. “Sebastian, Tinette, take the horrible things away!” Miss Rottenmeier was terrified of cats. She panicked and locked herself in another room.

Sebastian had seen the kittens in Heidi’s pockets when she came in. He had guessed what would happen. Now, he couldn’t help laughing. The mood lightened. Clara held the little kittens in her lap while Heidi knelt beside her. Sebastian agreed to take care of the kittens.

When it was bedtime, Miss Rottenmeier tiptoed to the door and quietly asked, “Are they gone?”

Sebastian said “Yes,” and quickly carried the kittens away.

Miss Rottenmeier was too tired from her scare earlier, so she decided to talk to Heidi the next day.

Everyone went to bed quietly. The children felt happy knowing their kittens had a comfy place to sleep.

